Chinese) territory. The risks of nuclear escalation were therefore greater than in the Caribbean or in Cuba. The fact that an order to fire was given places this incident in a category of its own. If John Bordne's story is reliable, Captain William Bassett has as strong a claim as any to be the Man Who Saved the World.

The man who wanted to blow up the world

In August 1961 Oleg Penkovsky learned that the border around West Berlin was to be sealed off four days before it happened.[12] He lacked the means to warn his case officers, so Western intelligence and Western leaders were taken by surprise when construction of the Berlin Wall began on 13 August. The lessons of this episode were quickly learned by SIS and CIA. A procedure (code-named DISTANT) was developed, by which Penkovsky could warn of an impending Soviet attack. According to Schecter and Deriabin:

> Penkovsky was given two phone numbers of American Embassy personnel, either of which he could ring. When a man answered the phone, Penkovsky was to blow into the mouthpiece three times, then wait one minute and repeat the procedure. The Americans would then go to telephone pole 35 on Kutuzovsky Prospekt and look for a freshly marked letter *X* on the pole. This signal meant that Penkovsky would leave a detailed message in the dead drop. If it was not possible for him to promptly service the dead drop, the phone signal would be sufficient for an immediate early warning. [13]

Penkovsky was told that DISTANT should be activated 'only if he had learned for a fact that the Soviet Union had decided to attack, or that the Soviets had decided to attack should the West take specific action, or that the Soviet Union had decided to attack should the West fail to undertake specific actions.'[14]